

Windows Explorer — Detailed Lecture Notes

JKSSB Computer Awareness

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20.1 What Windows Explorer is

Windows Explorer is the file-management program built into the Windows operating system. Its job is to let the user see and manage everything stored on the computer: drives, folders, and files. In Windows 10 and Windows 11 the same program is presented to the user as **File Explorer**. Internally it is the same program, whose executable file is **explorer.exe**. From one Explorer window a user can browse the entire tree of storage and perform the everyday operations of copying, moving, renaming, and deleting files.

Definition (Windows Explorer (File Explorer)). *The file-management program of Windows that displays drives, folders, and files in a graphical window and lets the user copy, move, rename, and delete them. It is launched from the executable **explorer.exe**.*

The main parts of the Explorer window are:

Part	What it shows
Navigation pane	The tree of drives and folders on the left.
Address bar	The full path of the folder that is currently open.
File list	The files and subfolders inside the current folder.
Ribbon / command bar	The tabs (New, Cut, Copy, Paste, Delete, View) for actions.
Search box	Files found inside the current folder matching the typed text.

20.2 Drives, folders, subfolders, and files

Storage is organised as a tree. At the top is a **drive**, identified by a drive letter. The hard disk is usually **C:**, and a USB flash drive might appear as **E:** or **F:**. A drive contains **folders**. A folder (also called a **directory**) is a container that holds files and other folders. A folder placed inside another folder is a **subfolder**. A **file** is a single item of stored data — a document, an image, a song, or a program.

Definition (Drive). *A storage device or partition on which folders and files are kept, named by a drive letter such as **C:** or **E:**.*

Definition (Folder (directory)). *A named container that holds files and other folders. A folder inside a folder is called a subfolder.*

Because folders can hold subfolders, and those can hold more subfolders, the whole arrangement looks like an inverted tree — the drive is the root, the folders are branches, and the files are the leaves. The top-most folder of a drive, directly under the drive letter, is called the **root folder**.

20.3 The file path

Every file and folder has one exact **path**: the address that tells Windows where it lives. The parts of a path are separated by a **backslash** (\). For example:

C:\Users\Student\Documents\report.docx

Reading left to right, **C:** is the drive, **Users**, **Student**, and **Documents** are the successive folders, and **report.docx** is the file name including its extension. The path is shown in the Explorer **address bar**, and the same information is given in a file's Properties as its **location**.

Definition (Path). *The complete address of a file or folder, from the drive letter through the chain of folders to the item's own name, with parts separated by a backslash.*

20.4 File names and extensions

A file name normally has two parts joined by a dot: the **name** and the **extension**. In **report.docx**, **report** is the name and **.docx** is the extension. The extension tells Windows which program should open the file and what kind of data it holds. Common extensions include **.txt** for a text file, **.docx** for a Word document, **.xlsx** for an Excel workbook, **.pptx** for a PowerPoint presentation, **.pdf** for a portable document, **.jpg** for a photo, and **.exe** for a program.

Extension	Type of file / format
.txt	Plain text file
.docx	Microsoft Word document
.xlsx	Microsoft Excel workbook
.pptx	Microsoft PowerPoint presentation
.pdf	Portable Document Format
.jpg	JPEG image
.exe	Executable program

Definition (Extension). *The letters after the last dot in a file name (for example **.docx**) that indicate the file's type and the program that opens it.*

One common confusion is between an *extension* and a *format*. An extension is the label at the end of the name, such as **.png**; the format is the way the data is actually encoded, such as PNG. The two usually match, but the words name different things, so they should not be used as interchangeable (TRM-09, TRAP-34).

20.5 Hidden files and attributes

Every file and folder carries **attributes**: settings that tell Windows how to treat it. The common attributes are **Read-only**, **Hidden**, **System**, and **Archive**. A **hidden file** or folder has the **Hidden** attribute set and is therefore not displayed by default. Windows hides important system files so that a user does not move or delete them by mistake. To display hidden items, open the **View** tab, choose **Show**, and then **Hidden items** (in Windows 10 and 11). In older versions the setting is reached through **Folder Options**.

Definition (File attribute). *A property that controls how Windows treats a file or folder, such as Read-only, Hidden, System, or Archive.*

20.6 Properties

Properties is the dialog box that displays the details of a selected file, folder, or drive. It is opened by pressing **Alt + Enter** or by choosing **right-click** → **Properties**. For a file, Properties shows the type (format), the size, the date created, the date modified, the location (path), and the attributes. For a drive, it shows the total size, the used space, and the free space. Properties is a read-and-sometimes-edit view: changes to attributes may be made there, but the file's contents are not shown.

20.7 Selecting files

Before a file can be copied, moved, renamed, or deleted it must be selected. A single file is selected by clicking it once. A **contiguous range** of files is selected by clicking the first file, holding **Shift**, and clicking the last file. **Non-contiguous** files are selected by holding **Ctrl** and clicking each file in turn. All files in a folder are selected with **Ctrl + A**.

Selection	Method
One file	Click once.
A block of files in a row	Click the first, hold Shift, click the last.
Separate files scattered in the list	Hold Ctrl and click each.
Every file in the folder	Ctrl + A.

20.8 Copy

Copy makes a duplicate of the selected item while leaving the original where it is. The usual method is to press **Ctrl + C** to copy, open the destination folder, and press **Ctrl + V** to paste. The same steps can be done with **right-click** → **Copy** followed by **Paste**. Holding **Ctrl** while dragging an item also copies it. The key point about copy is that after the operation there are *two* copies: the original and the new one.

Example 20.8.1. *A student copies `report.docx` from Documents to a USB drive. After pasting, the file exists in both places. The copy in Documents is unchanged, because Copy never removes the original.*

20.9 Move

Move shifts the selected item to a new location and removes it from the old one. The standard way is to **cut** with **Ctrl + X**, open the destination, and **paste** with **Ctrl + V**. Cut followed by Paste is therefore the standard move operation. Alternatively, dragging a file to a folder on the **same drive** moves it. Dragging to a folder on a **different drive** copies it instead, because Windows assumes you intend to transfer a copy between separate devices.

Definition (Move). *Relocating a file or folder from one place to another so that it no longer exists at the old location. Cut + Paste performs a move.*

20.10 Rename

Rename changes only the **name** of a file or folder; its contents are untouched. The quickest method is to select the item and press **F2**, type the new name, and press **Enter**. The same command is available by right-clicking the item and choosing **Rename**. A warning worth remembering: changing the text after the dot can change the file's recognised type, so the extension should be left alone unless the type is genuinely being changed.

20.11 Delete and the Recycle Bin

Pressing the **Delete** key on a selected item moves it to the **Recycle Bin**. The Recycle Bin is a special folder that temporarily holds deleted items, giving the user a chance to recover them. An item in the Recycle Bin may be **restored** to its original location; the **Restore** command puts it back. Choosing **Empty Recycle Bin** deletes everything held in the Bin permanently.

Definition (Recycle Bin). *A special Windows folder that temporarily stores files and folders deleted with the Delete key, so that they can be restored or removed permanently.*

20.12 Recycle Bin vs permanent deletion

An item deleted with **Delete** is recoverable, because it sits in the Recycle Bin until the Bin is emptied. Permanent deletion happens when the user presses **Shift + Delete**, when the Recycle Bin is emptied, or when an item is deleted from a **USB drive**, a **network drive**, or another location that does not use the Recycle Bin. Once deleted permanently, a file cannot be restored through the normal Windows interface.

Point	Recycle Bin (Delete)	Permanent deletion
Shortcut	Delete key	Shift + Delete
Recoverable	Yes, can be restored	No, cannot be restored
Stored where	Recycle Bin folder	Removed from the disk

Permanent deletion does not mean the storage space is instantly overwritten; the freed space is simply marked as available for reuse. For exam purposes the distinction is the one that matters: Delete is recoverable, Shift+Delete is not.

20.13 Keyboard shortcuts and drag-and-drop

The following shortcuts are high-yield for the exam and should be memorised exactly.

Action	Shortcut
Copy	Ctrl + C
Cut (move)	Ctrl + X
Paste	Ctrl + V
Undo	Ctrl + Z
Select all	Ctrl + A
Rename	F2
Refresh	F5
Properties	Alt + Enter
New folder	Ctrl + Shift + N
Delete to Recycle Bin	Delete
Permanent delete	Shift + Delete

Drag-and-drop follows a fixed rule. Dragging an item to a folder on the **same drive moves** it; dragging to a folder on a **different drive copies** it. Holding **Ctrl** while dragging always **copies**, and holding **Shift** while dragging always **moves**, regardless of the drives involved.

20.14 Exam retrieval and common confusions

Five distinctions prevent most errors on this topic.

1. **Copy** leaves the original in place; **move** (Cut + Paste) removes it. Do not confuse the two.
2. The **Delete** key sends a file to the **Recycle Bin**; it is not a permanent erase. **Shift + Delete** is the permanent erase and bypasses the Bin.
3. Deleting from a **USB drive** or **network drive** bypasses the Recycle Bin even when the plain Delete key is used.
4. An **extension** is the label after the dot (for example **.png**); it is not the same as the **format** (PNG) (TRM-09).
5. Same-drive drag **moves**; different-drive drag **copies**. **Ctrl+drag** forces a copy; **Shift+drag** forces a move.

Example 20.14.1. *An item asks where a file goes when the Delete key is pressed. Trace the rule: the Delete key moves the item to the Recycle Bin, from which it can still be restored. If the stem instead says the file must be removed so that it cannot be recovered, the required operation is Shift+Delete (or emptying the Recycle Bin), not the plain Delete key.*

Exercises

1. What is Windows Explorer called in Windows 11, and what is the name of its executable program?
2. Distinguish between a folder and a subfolder, and define a file path.
3. What is a file extension, and why is an extension not the same as a file format?
4. Explain the difference between Copy and Move, and give the keyboard shortcut for each.
5. A file is deleted with the Delete key. Can it be recovered? Explain, and state one way to delete a file permanently.

Solutions

1. In Windows 11 it is called **File Explorer**. Its executable program is **explorer.exe**.
2. A folder is a container that holds files and other folders; a folder placed inside another folder is a subfolder. A path is the complete address of a file or folder, from the drive letter through the chain of folders to the item's own name, with parts separated by a backslash.
3. An extension is the letters after the last dot in a file name (for example **.docx**) that indicate the file's type. It is not the same as the format, because the extension is only the label at the end of the name, while the format is the way the data is actually encoded.
4. **Copy** duplicates the item and leaves the original in place (Ctrl + C, then Ctrl + V). **Move** relocates the item and removes it from the old location (Ctrl + X, then Ctrl + V).
5. Yes, a file deleted with the Delete key can normally be recovered, because it goes to the Recycle Bin and can be restored. It can be deleted permanently with **Shift + Delete** (or by emptying the Recycle Bin).